

SKOAR!: 7.5/10
Developer: Volition Software
Publisher: THQ
Distributor: E-xpress
Interactive
Price: 2,499
Platform: Xbox 360, PS3

What We Love

Lots of customisation offered
A lot to do and it's all fun!
Great sense of (dark) humour

What We Hate

Weak plot
Graphical issues

Saints Row 2

Lots Of Fun

Agent001

How cool is it to play a gangster? So cool. If there is any doubt, *Saints Row 2* smashes home the point with great style and conviction. The premise of the game is not much different from any other in this genre – you were once a kingpin of the city named Stillwater, a city allegedly based on real life Chicago and Detroit. You start the game in a prison, waking up from a state of comatose and realise that your former kingdom has been usurped by three other gangs. The wafer-thin plot of the game is set in the first ten minutes or so and your missions are quite obvious – send the other gangbangers to meet their maker and regain your control over the city. Now, this may not sound very exiting – which it is not – however the game is a lot of fun as you go around town, wreaking havoc like an unhinged maniac.

The game shines right from the outset, from the customisation options offered while you create your character: suffice to say that you can really let your creativity go wild as you sculpt your in-game avatar. Mind you, the game isn't exactly a looker, in fact there are some horrible graphical issues that you will bump into from time to time. However, if you can look beyond these niggles the game redeems itself with some incredibly fun missions and activities (the game calls them diversions). It is also very tongue-in-cheek, poking fun and confronting some of the issues of our decadent civilization head on. Some of these 'mini-missions' are the common variety such as: drug dealing, car-jacking, and so on, but the game also offers some over the top mission such as rescuing prostitutes from their mistreating pimps, masquerading as a police officer and taking down crime with excessive force for the benefit of the local news channel, and even taking a helicopter ride of mayhem and destruction with gun cannons and missiles.

The map of the Stillwater is divided into three major territories that are controlled by individual gangs. Your primary objective is to regain these territories by completing certain missions and taking over their strongholds. As you progress towards regaining power (and money) you can upgrade your stronghold with better vehicles, arm your homies with better gear, and pimp your crib with a home theatre system and even stripper poles. Further character customisation include getting a new hairdo, sick tattoos, altering your melee fighting style, and if you feel like getting in touch with your feminine side – the game even allows you to indulge in some cross dressing. No respectable gangster should be seen riding a stock car, so the game features shops across the city where you can take your favorite ride and pimp it up with upgrades like hydraulics, spoilers, custom body and even nitro.

I am generally not a fan of these kinds of games; in fact, I have only slightly liked games such as the Grand Theft Auto series. There are a couple of things this game does to set itself apart from the competition. Firstly, the main plot of the game is relatively personal, where your motives are your own and you are not working for anyone but yourself. Adding to that is a really fun and unpretentious game play coupled with a really sick sense of humor; this is a game that never takes itself too seriously.

If you've not been too impressed by sandbox-styled action adventure games in the past, this may very well be the game that'll change your mind.*

